



An artiste only has a relationship with art. But if he has a relationship with a political party, it is different. Amitabh Bachchan says that he is apolitical and has left all political associations behind. He told Editor PRABHU CHAWLA in Seedhi Baat on Aaj Tak that he works only as an actor.

Q. You are far removed from politics, but have been pulled into a political game. Does it hurt?

A. Not at all. I am clean at heart and I have nothing to do with politics. But if any person wants to make any links or intends to express any views, it is his opinion. I don't want to get into that.

Q. Do Congress workers imagine that you have a relationship with their party on their own?

A. The Congress is a huge party. It runs the nation and it has been running the nation for a long time. How can a little person like me get after such a big party?

Q. Congress's Kripa Shankar Singh has said that your being Narendra Modi's brand ambassador makes it difficult to share a platform with you.

A. Not Modi's ambassador. I would like to clarify that Gujarat is a part of our country and I am promoting tourism there. I am a citizen of this country and have a right to promote any part of the country. What else have I done? I am not publicising the Gujarat Government or Chief Minister Narendra Modi because I am not into politics. There is no commercial angle in this. I don't charge anything when I work for a social cause. I have not charged anything from the Gujarat Government.

Q. Didn't you feel the Gujarat Government assignment would create an atmosphere where Congressmen would react against you?

A. I didn't imagine that. I hadn't also thought that a citizen of India could become a sort of untouchable if he talks about the grandeur of the nation.

Q. Are there any issues that the Congress workers are unaware of?

A. That is not my responsibility. It is the Congress's job to let their people understand. They can ask their workers not to meet me. I shall accept that.

Q. You have enjoyed an excellent relationship with the Congress and also Rajiv Gandhi. But you had told me earlier on Seedhi Baat that they have closed their doors to you.

A. See, these are age-old family relations built up long ago during the era of Babuji, Panditji and Sarojini Naidu. Naidu was an admirer of Babuji and she introduced Babuji to Panditji and this family relationship lasted with Indiraji, Rajivji, Soniaji and Sanjayji. I always respect that relationship.

Q. But shouldn't someone take the initiative to open the closed doors?

A. My doors will always remain open. But if anybody has closed doors, you can go and ask them why they don't want to meet.

It is for a social cause. There is no commercial angle. I have not charged anything from the Gujarat Government.

Subroto Roy. It was an association that increased his clout but may have eroded his stature. While Roy fell out with them around 2005, coincidentally after a period when the Government put his company affairs under scrutiny, Ambani has chosen to concentrate on staying on the right side of an establishment that is clearly closer to his brother with whom he is engaged in a fight to the finish over the gas case. Amar Singh's status as Mulayam Singh Yadav's Celebrity Collector-in-Chief has been replaced with the uncomfortable position of a Samajwadi Party outcast.

The Congress is treating Bachchan with disrespect simply because it can—imagine it offending a similar national treasure like Lata Mangeshkar or Sachin Tendulkar without a public outcry. Bachchan's own brand, despite the addition of one of India's premier actors, Aishwarya Rai, and the commercial success of the home movie, *Paa*, has seen a decline. At 68, he is no longer the force

IN THE LINE OF FIRE: THE BACHCHANS, FATHER AND SON, ARE BOTH CONGRESS TARGETS



YOGEN SHAH